

outdoor campaign. Spots for radio and FM stations will be done by Utopia and Big FM. In response to the Congress's 'Jai Ho' campaign, the party has roped in popular singers Shaan and Roop Kumar Rathod to sing publicity jingles and campaign songs—most of them to be penned by Advani's favourite Prasoon Joshi.

Team Advani, comprising trusted aide Deepak Chopra, psephologist GVL Narasimha Rao, chief election manager Arun Jaitley, RSS veteran Ram Lal, spokesperson Siddharth Nath Singh and Rajya Sabha member Balbir Punj, put their minds together to finalise strategies. Advani himself has visited the war room only a couple of times, but daughter Pratibha comes more often. Though Ananth Kumar is also a part of the group (and the owner of the house), he has been keeping away, busy with his own campaigning.

Straddling both the sections, the hi-tech communication office and the conference room, is Advani's political adviser Sudheendra Kulkarni. From writing Advani's speeches to managing his website and handling routine communication, 52-year-old Kulkarni is the key person in these elections. Some lovingly call him Advani's Hanuman. A B.Tech from IIT Mumbai and a former journalist, Kulkarni's enthusiasm is infectious. He comes into office before 9 am and works tirelessly till midnight, the last one to leave. And in his small cramped office, he also keeps a folding bed hidden under his

THE CONGRESS TROIKA (RIGHT) AND THE BJP LEADER (BOTTOM) SEEK A TICKET TO RIDE



SUBIR HALDAR

Behind the Battle

The key people manning the war rooms



CONGRESS

Resident Expert: Jairam Ramesh

Ace Strategist: Digvijay Singh

Choreographer-in-chief: Ahmed Patel

Wordsmiths: Salman Khurshid and Anand Sharma

Soundbite Stylist: Veerappa Moily



BJP

Brain Power: Sudheendra Kulkarni

Number Cruncher: GVL Narasimha Rao

Ace Strategist: Arun Jaitley

Eyes and Ears: Deepak Chopra

Cyber Warrior: Prodyut Bora

table. He uses it occasionally to rest if things become too hectic. Talking about the campaign, he says, "It's innovative in its ability to touch the lives of people. We want to project an image of a party that has a grand vision combined with the ability to deliver."

The party's track record under the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government speaks for itself. "We gave world-class highways to the country, the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana, connecting lakhs of villages, and also the world's largest elementary education programme in Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan. Now, the party promises to give an IT revolution," says Kulkarni. Like a true team leader, he refuses to take credit for Advani's backroom power. He says it is his young team which deserves all accolades, as he introduces the newest volunteer, Harsh Vardhan Chhaparia, an IIM-Calcutta graduate who is to join McKinsey in three months.

Led by Prodyut Bora, the IT team boasts of Mallika Noorani, 23, who quit her job in a multinational bank in Mumbai, software expert Robin Roppai, formerly a management consultant with Pricewaterhouse Coopers, Bhanuchandar, a Johns Hopkins graduate, Zorawar Daulet Singh and Anay Joglekar, who has taken a sabbatical from his job in an embassy in Mumbai. They are all zealously working, hoping to make a difference to the party—and the biggest difference in the life of their youthful 81-year old idol. ■

SUBIR HALDAR

